

Boys are from Room 103; Girls are from Room 104

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Everyone has seen the memes and/or diatribes about the differences between men and women, almost always within the context of courtship. "Men need to stop doing ABC" or "Women need to spend more time spitting in my XYZ" or something more-or-less like that.

Completely ignoring the insufferable heteronormativity of it all, the core issue underlying your superficial complaints is not hard to see if you can just poke your heads up through the clouds of resentment long enough. And let's be real, if I can do it, so can you, ok?

Men hurt women and women hurt men. We both pretend to be strong around others and we both cry in private. It might have started small (or perhaps not, but just bear with me). The emotion that started this hellacious chain of events was most likely insecurity. But insecurity never travels alone; poetic, isn't it?

STORY TIME

One fine day at recess, your mere presence caused some other 6-year-old to feel insecure. Maybe their insecurity was riding shotgun to envy or inadequacy or perhaps even jealousy (which is not the same as envy, btw). So they walked up to you with all of the fake toughness and self-assuredness they can muster and launched into a full-on assault of whatever thing you did or attribute you possessed that caused them to feel some way that was unpleasant to them. Having caught you completely off-guard and feeling that their case was air-tight and masterfully presented, they saunter off enjoying the relief of no longer being possessed of those unpleasant feelings.

As it happens, you were a young girl and the insecure person just happened to be a young boy. Despite the issue itself having nothing to do with sexuality, it is a difference that we take note of and that begins to create the us-versus-them mentality that we carry with us throughout the rest of our lives (unless we take conscious action to reprogram ourselves of it).

So the little girl got her feelings hurt through a random act of aggression from a little boy. That's what is locked away in the girl's mind. Because that experience was unpleasant and because there was no identifiable provocation, the girl is left puzzled about what to do to avoid having such incidents recur. Thus, there is no other conclusion to be reached other than "boys are unstable" and/or "boys secretly hate girls and this rage can come to the surface at any moment even without provocation".

Girls soon discover that the only way they can "win" in any such encounter is to take a strong offensive position. The phrase "the best defense is a strong offense" is very appropriate here. Recognizing that

boys' toughness is just an act, the girls realize that they can be hurt in much the same way that girls can. The trick is to get your punches in early or else you'll be stunned into inaction by the way that boys tend to dominate and control the interaction.

Some other fine day at recess another boy has an emotion, a pleasant one this time. He doesn't understand it, he just knows that it feels good to hang around close to you. So he does. Being now hypervigilant, this boy's movements and proximity to you do not escape your attention for a millisecond. But you pretend not to notice so that you don't appear paranoid in front of your friends. But now he's so close that you can literally feel his breath on the back of your neck. Surely his behavior has crossed the line of social acceptability and no one would fault you for reacting...

"Back off... $C \in P$!"

The little boy bursts into tears and runs away, having experienced his very first rejection at the hands of a mean girl. To literally add insult to injury, he must cope with the weight of this new label that has just been applied to him and is now burning its way through the landscape of his young mind like hot lava.

Naturally, this completely unprovoked hostility must be reconciled in some way. Obviously, it requires uncommon skills and techniques to be able to approach girls without triggering their rage.

Or perhaps not. Maybe there is no way to avoid triggering their rage because girls are inherently irrational. Might it be that the genders are so fundamentally different that the best that can be hoped for is merely isolated occurrences of well-understood interpersonal interactions governed by the laws of economics? Surely not...

CONCLUSION

If you want to experience more effective communication with members of your preferred gender, talk directly to that 6-year-old boy or girl. Tell them you're sorry for hurting their feelings. Help them to see the members of your gender as sources of comfort and support rather than ridicule and judgment.

And most of all, be far gentler with one another. We're all hurting. More hurt isn't going to change anything. But love will.

Goodnight, all.